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Edexcel GCSE Geography B (1GB0) — Component 2: UK Geographical Issues · Topic 4: The UK's Evolving Physical Landscape (4B River processes and pressures)

2.2 River Processes and Pressures

1. The River as a System

A river and its drainage basin function as an **open system** — water, sediment, and energy enter, are processed, and leave. Understanding this systems framework underpins all river processes and landforms.

Key Drainage Basin Terms

Drainage basin: The area of land drained by a river and its tributaries. Also called a **catchment area**. It is bounded by a **watershed** (the ridge of high land separating one drainage basin from another).

Watershed: The boundary (usually a ridge) separating one drainage basin from another. Precipitation falling on one side flows into a different river system.

Tributary: A smaller stream or river that joins a larger one.

Confluence: The point where two rivers or streams join.

Source: The origin (usually highest point) of a river, often a spring, bog, or lake.

Mouth: Where the river meets the sea or a lake. Discharge is greatest here.

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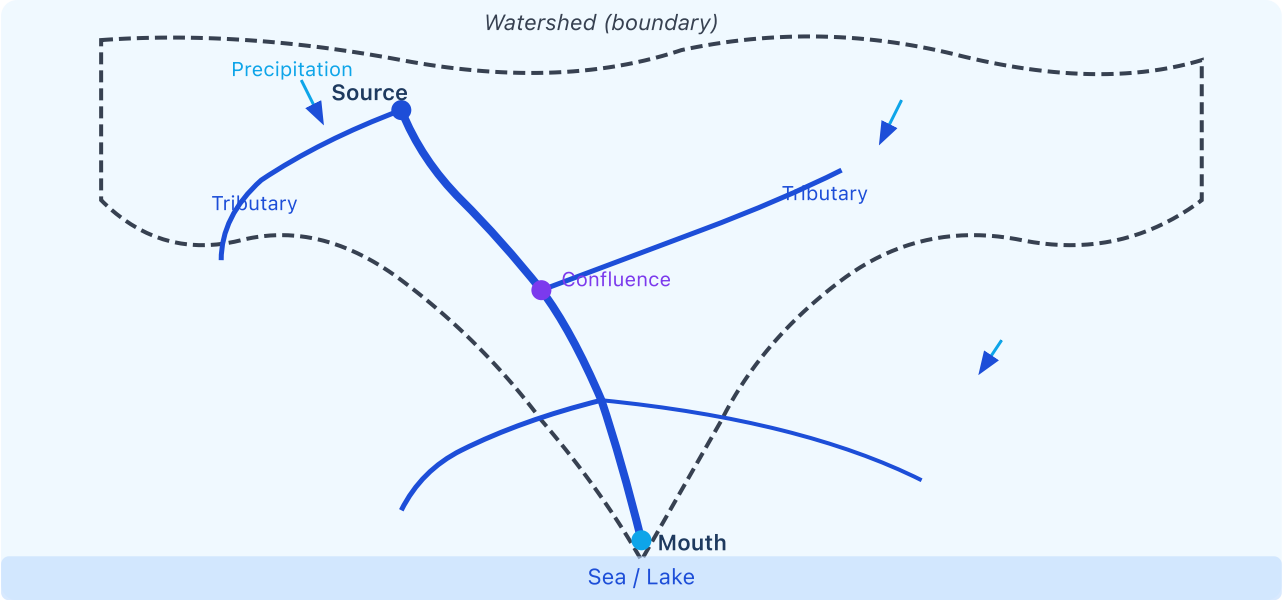


Fig 2.1 — A drainage basin showing watershed, source, tributaries, confluence, and mouth

Inputs, Throughputs, and Outputs

Component	Description
Input	Precipitation (rain, snow, sleet) — enters the drainage basin as water
Infiltration	Water soaking into the soil; rate depends on soil type, saturation, vegetation
Surface runoff (overland flow)	Water flowing over land surface when infiltration capacity is exceeded; fast — reaches river quickly
Throughflow	Water moving through the soil layer, parallel to the slope; moderate speed
Groundwater flow	Slow movement of water through permeable rock; sustains rivers during dry spells (base flow)
Output: River discharge	Volume of water passing a point per second (cumecs, m^3/s); measured at gauging stations
Output: Evapotranspiration	Water lost to atmosphere through evaporation + plant transpiration; higher in summer

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2. River Processes

Erosion

Hydraulic Action: The force of flowing water pushing into cracks and joints in the river bed and banks. The pressure compresses air, weakens rock, and can dislodge large blocks. Most effective during floods.

Abrasion (Corrasion): The load carried by the river (pebbles, sand) acts like sandpaper, scraping and grinding the bed and banks. Responsible for vertical and lateral erosion; creates smooth, polished channels.

Attrition: Particles of load collide with each other, becoming progressively smaller, rounder, and smoother as they travel downstream. Explains why large angular boulders near the source become small, round pebbles near the mouth.

Corrosion (Solution): Slightly acidic river water chemically dissolves soluble minerals (e.g., calcium carbonate in limestone). The dissolved material is carried in solution. Example: limestone karst landscapes.

Rivers also erode in different directions: **vertical erosion** (downward, deepening the channel — dominant in upper course) and **lateral erosion** (sideways, widening the channel — dominant in middle and lower course).

Transportation

Process	Sediment type	Description
Traction	Boulders, cobbles	Largest material rolled along the river bed by the current
Saltation	Pebbles, coarse sand	Bounced along the bed in a series of hops

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Suspension	Fine silt, clay	Carried within the water column; gives rivers brown colour after heavy rain
Solution	Dissolved minerals	Carried invisibly in the water; always in transport regardless of velocity

Deposition

Deposition occurs when a river loses **energy** (velocity decreases) and can no longer carry its load. This happens when: gradient decreases (entering a flood plain), discharge falls (drought, abstraction), the river meets the sea (loses velocity), or on the inside of meander bends (reduced velocity). The largest/heaviest material is deposited first.

The Hjulström Curve

The Hjulström curve shows the relationship between water velocity and sediment behaviour (erosion, transport, deposition):

- **Erosion velocity** — the minimum velocity needed to pick up (entrain) sediment of a given size. Coarser sediment requires more velocity; but importantly, fine clays also need relatively high velocity because they are cohesive (stuck together).
- **Settling/deposition velocity** — the velocity at which a particle is deposited. This is always lower than erosion velocity.
- **Key point:** Once in transport, fine silt/clay can be carried at very low velocities. Large boulders require very high velocities to be entrained, but once moving, they are deposited as soon as velocity drops below transport velocity.

> **Exam Tip:** The Hjulström curve is tricky — remember that fine clays require a surprisingly high velocity to erode (because they are cohesive), but once in suspension they stay in transport at very low velocities. For boulders: high velocity to move, and deposited rapidly when velocity drops.

3. The Long Profile and Changes Downstream

The **long profile** of a river is a cross-section from source to mouth, showing how gradient changes. Near the source, the gradient is steep; by the lower course, it has almost flattened out, forming a

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smooth concave curve called the **graded profile**.

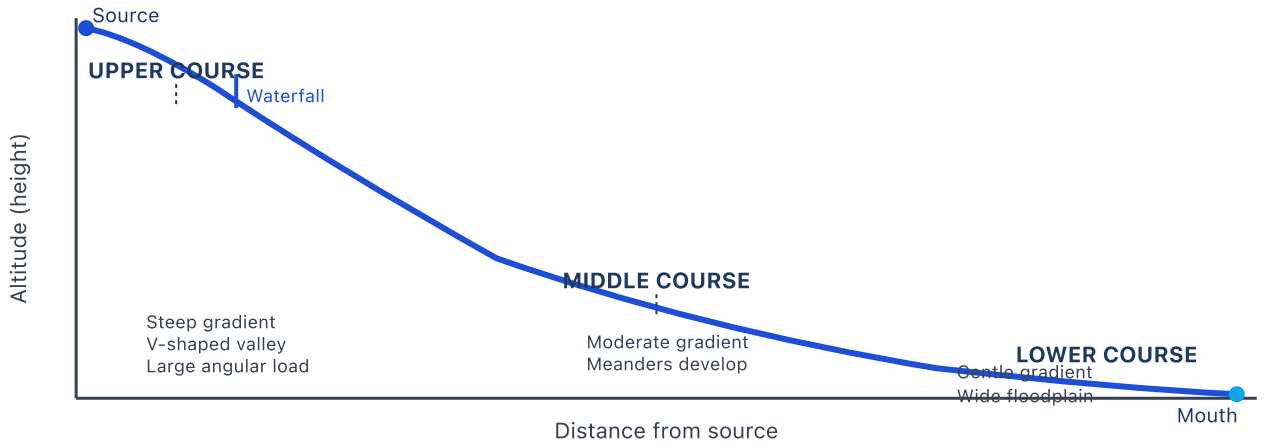


Fig 2.2 — River long profile (concave shape) showing upper, middle, and lower course characteristics

Variable	Upper Course	Middle Course	Lower Course
Gradient	Steep	Moderate	Gentle/flat
Velocity	Low (high friction)	Increasing	Fastest overall
Discharge	Lowest	Increasing (tributaries)	Highest
Channel width	Narrow	Wider	Widest
Channel depth	Shallow	Deeper	Deepest
Load size	Large, angular boulders	Pebbles, gravels	Fine sand, silt
Dominant erosion	Vertical (deepening)	Lateral (widening)	Lateral (very wide)
Valley shape	V-shaped, narrow	Wider, flatter floor	Broad, flat floodplain

4. Upper Course Landforms

V-Shaped Valleys and Interlocking Spurs

In the upper course, the river mainly erodes **vertically**, cutting downward into the bedrock. The valley sides are steep because:

- Rainwater washes material off steep valley sides (mass movement and surface wash)
- The valley floor is narrow — little lateral erosion
- Weathering (freeze-thaw) loosens material on the valley sides which falls into the river

The resulting valley has a classic **V-shape**. The river winds around resistant spurs of rock, which jut into the valley from alternate sides — these are called **interlocking spurs**.

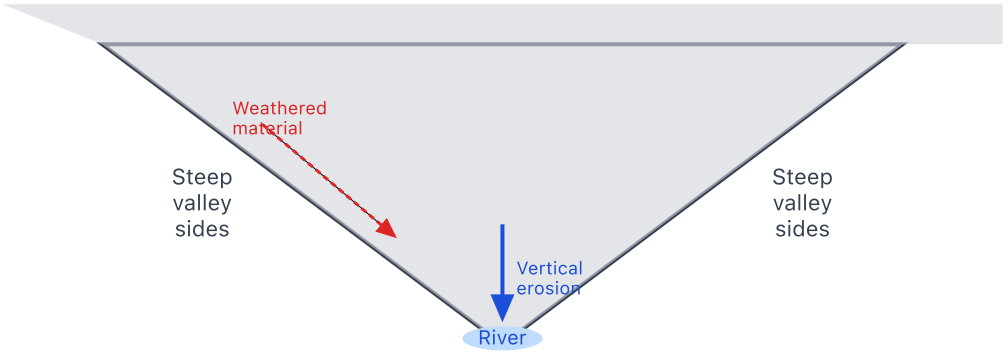


Fig 2.3 — V-shaped valley cross-section: vertical erosion by river + weathering of valley sides

Waterfalls and Gorges

Waterfalls form where a river crosses a band of **resistant rock** overlying softer rock. The sequence of formation:

1. The river flows over the hard rock cap; beneath, softer rock erodes faster by hydraulic action and abrasion
2. A **plunge pool** forms at the base where the falling water churns the rock
3. The hard cap rock is undercut and becomes unsupported; eventually it collapses
4. The waterfall retreats upstream, leaving a steep-sided **gorge** in its wake

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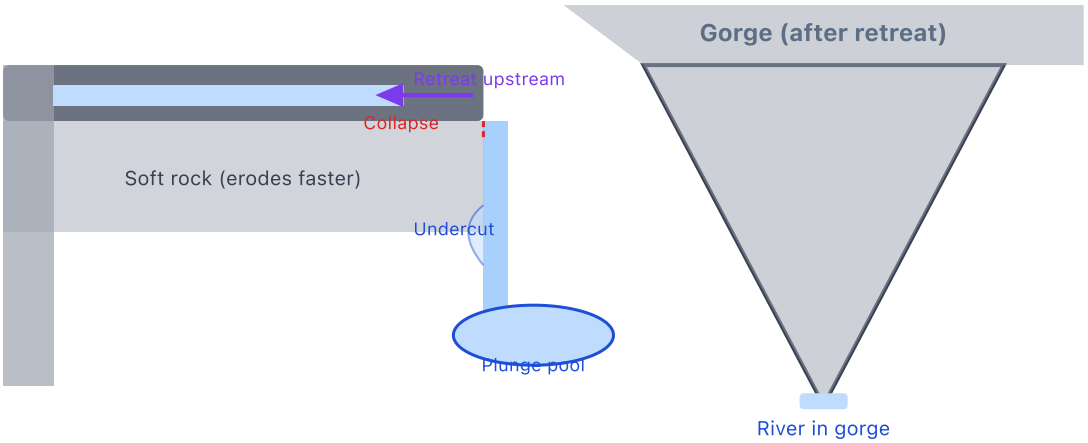


Fig 2.4 — Waterfall formation and retreat, leaving a gorge. Example: High Force, River Tees, County Durham

Example: High Force, River Tees — often described as England's largest waterfall by volume. Hard Whin Sill dolerite overlies softer Carboniferous limestone; the waterfall has retreated ~700 m to form a gorge.

5. Middle Course Landforms

Meanders

As the river enters the middle course, the valley widens and the river begins to swing in wide bends called **meanders**. They develop because of differences in velocity across the channel:

- On the **outer bend** — faster flow (greater centrifugal force), erosion by abrasion and hydraulic action creates a steep **river cliff** (cut bank)
- On the **inner bend** — slower flow, deposition builds up a **slip-off slope** (point bar) of sand and gravel
- A secondary **helical (corkscrew) flow** called **helicoidal flow** moves water and sediment from the outer bank to the inner bend, enhancing the asymmetric shape

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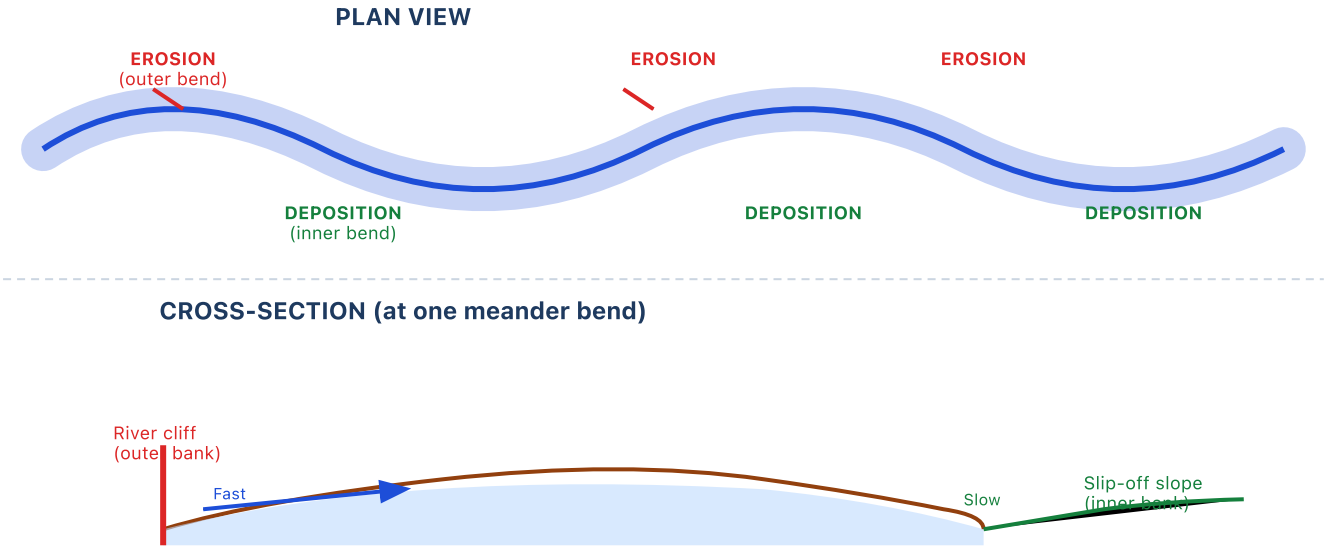


Fig 2.5 — Meander plan view (top) and cross-section (bottom) showing river cliff on outer bank and slip-off slope on inner bank

6. Lower Course Landforms

Ox-bow Lakes

Ox-bow lakes form from meanders through a 4-stage process:

1. The meander bends become increasingly tight (tortuous) as erosion continues on outer bends
2. During a flood, the river cuts through the narrow neck of land between two adjacent meander bends (the shortest route)
3. The river straightens, depositing sediment (alluvium) at both ends of the old meander loop
4. The abandoned meander bend is cut off, forming a horseshoe-shaped **ox-bow lake**
5. Over time, the ox-bow dries up, leaving a curved **meander scar**

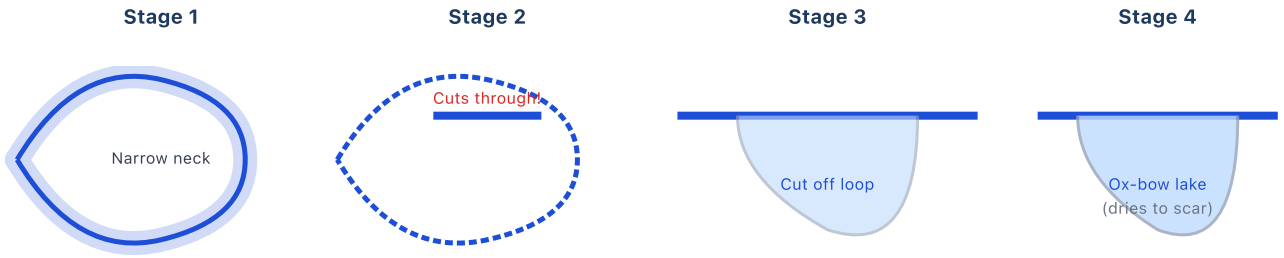


Fig 2.6 — Four-stage formation of an ox-bow lake from a meander

Flood Plains

A **flood plain** is the flat, low-lying area either side of the river channel, formed by repeated flooding and lateral erosion. During floods, the river overtops its banks and velocity drops immediately — sediment (alluvium) is deposited across the flood plain, gradually building it up. Flood plains are the most fertile agricultural land due to mineral-rich alluvium.

Levées

Natural embankments alongside river channels. During floods, coarsest sediment is deposited immediately adjacent to the channel (as velocity falls sharply at the bank). Over many flood events, these deposits build up to form **levées**. They may raise the channel above the level of the surrounding flood plain. When levées breach (break), flooding can be catastrophic (e.g., Yellow River, China; Mississippi, USA).

Deltas

Deltas form at river mouths where sediment load is deposited faster than it can be removed by tidal currents or waves. The river splits into distributaries. Two main types:

- **Arcuate delta** — fan-shaped, smoothed by wave action. Example: Nile Delta, Egypt
- **Bird's foot delta** — long, finger-like distributaries extending into calm water. Example: Mississippi Delta, USA

7. Storm Hydrographs

A **storm hydrograph** shows how river discharge responds to a rainfall event over time. It is a key tool for flood prediction and management.

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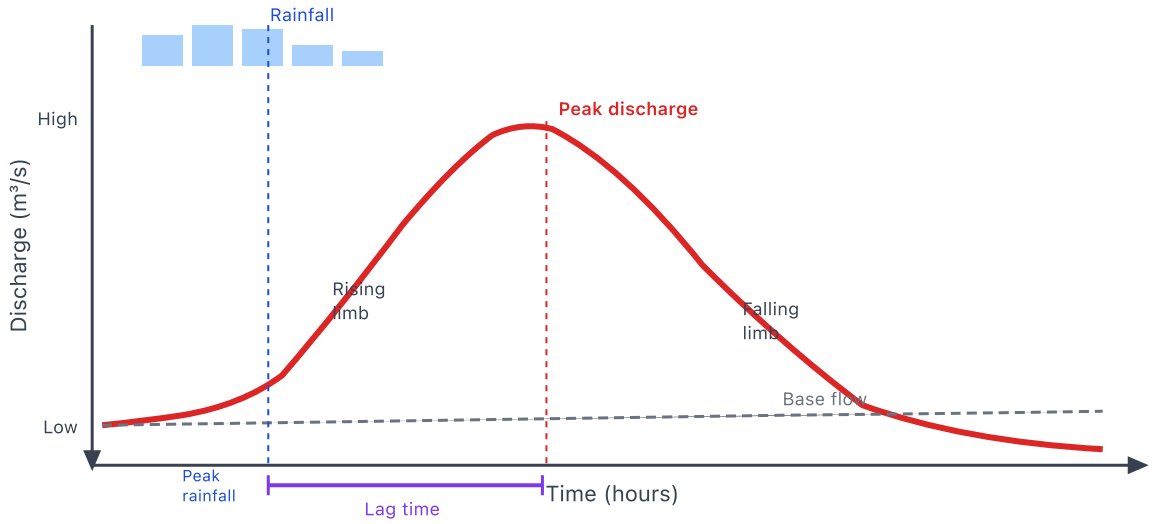


Fig 2.7 — A storm hydrograph showing key components

Key Components

Term	Definition
Rising limb	The rising section of the graph as discharge increases after rainfall
Peak discharge	The maximum discharge reached after a storm event (m³/s)
Lag time	The time delay between peak rainfall and peak discharge; shorter = flashier = more flood risk
Falling limb (recession limb)	The gradual decrease in discharge as water drains away
Base flow	The background level of discharge sustained by groundwater between storms

Factors Affecting Hydrograph Shape

Factor	Flashy hydrograph (short lag, high peak)	Subdued hydrograph (long lag, low peak)

Land use	Urban areas (impermeable tarmac, drains)	Forest/pasture (infiltration, interception)
Rock type	Impermeable rock (granite, clay)	Permeable rock (chalk, sandstone)
Rainfall intensity	Heavy, intense, short storm	Light, prolonged drizzle
Vegetation	Bare soil, arable fields, deforested	Dense woodland, grassland
Slope angle	Steep slopes — rapid runoff	Gentle slopes — slow runoff
Antecedent soil moisture	Already saturated soil — rapid runoff	Dry soil — high infiltration capacity

Exam Tip: When describing a hydrograph, always quote figures: "peak discharge of X m³/s", "lag time of Y hours". When explaining hydrograph shape, give reasons linked to the specific drainage basin characteristics — e.g., "the short lag time of 2 hours suggests an urbanised catchment with impermeable surfaces and efficient drainage systems."

8. Causes and Effects of Flooding

Physical Causes

- **Prolonged rainfall** — saturates soil, reducing infiltration; surface runoff increases rapidly
- **Heavy, intense storms** — rainfall exceeds infiltration capacity immediately
- **Snowmelt** — rapid melting in spring (especially when combined with rain) releases large volumes of water
- **Impermeable rock** (granite, clay) — little water infiltrates, most runs off
- **Steep slopes** — water reaches the river channel quickly
- **Low vegetation cover** — less interception and transpiration

Human Causes

- **Urbanisation** — tarmac, concrete, and rooftops are impermeable; drains deliver water rapidly to rivers, reducing lag time and increasing peak discharge
- **Deforestation** — trees intercept rainfall and roots absorb water; removing trees increases runoff and reduces evapotranspiration
- **Floodplain development** — building on flood plains removes natural storage capacity and increases flood risk downstream
- **Overgrazing and compaction** — compacted soils reduce infiltration rates
- **Climate change** — more intense rainfall events; changing precipitation patterns

Case Study: Boscastle Flash Flood, Cornwall, August 2004

Event: On 16 August 2004, exceptionally heavy convective rainfall (about 185 mm on high ground in around 5 hours, with 89 mm in one hour at Boscastle — often quoted as a 1-in-400-year event) fell over the small drainage basin of the River Valency and River Jordan above Boscastle village.

Physical causes:

- Intense, localised convectional rainfall triggered by a stationary low-pressure system on a hot August day
- Steep valley sides and impermeable Devonian slate bedrock — rapid surface runoff
- Small, steep drainage basin with short lag time
- Soils already saturated from previous days of rain

Effects:

- Flood peak estimated at 140 m^3/s (normally ~1 m^3/s) — a 140-fold increase
- Floodwaters reached 3 m deep in the narrow village street
- About 80 cars, plus caravans and boats, swept out to sea; four bridges destroyed; B3263 road badly damaged
- Around 60 properties flooded in Boscastle and about 100 homes and businesses damaged or destroyed across the area
- No deaths (thanks to emergency services); about 150 people rescued by seven helicopters

Management responses:

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- The valley was redeveloped with a flood alleviation scheme: river channel widened and deepened; culverts removed; car park relocated to higher ground
- New footbridge designed to allow debris to pass through
- Costs: damage estimated at tens of millions of pounds; the Environment Agency's flood defence scheme (completed 2008) cost around £4.6 million

9. River Management Strategies

Hard Engineering

Strategy	Description	Advantages	Disadvantages
Dams and reservoirs	Large concrete structures built across river valleys; reservoir stores water, controlling release	Highly effective flood control; HEP generation; water supply; recreation	Extremely expensive; displaces communities; traps sediment (delta starvation downstream); dam failure catastrophic; destroys habitats
Channel straightening (channelisation)	Meanders cut off to create a straight channel; may line channel with concrete	Water removed faster; reduces local flooding	Increases flooding downstream (water arrives faster); destroys habitat; unnatural; channel can re-meander
Embankments (artificial levées)	Raised earthen or concrete banks along river channel to contain flood water	Relatively cheap; can raise height over time; allows floodplain use	If breached, flooding is catastrophic; increases flood risk downstream; regular maintenance needed
Flood relief channels	Parallel channels dug to carry overflow when main channel is in flood	Effective; can be designed to specific discharge; reduces	Land take; expensive to construct; only effective if correctly sized for design flood

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		pressure on main channel	

Soft Engineering

Strategy	Description	Advantages	Disadvantages
Afforestation	Planting trees in the drainage basin to increase interception and infiltration	Sustainable; cheap; improves biodiversity; carbon sequestration; reduces runoff long-term	Takes decades to be effective; may reduce agricultural productivity of upland areas
Floodplain zoning	Planning regulations prevent development on flood-risk areas; land left as parks, recreation	Prevents building in flood zones; relatively cheap; maintains natural floodplain function	Restricts development in areas where land is scarce; planning enforcement required; does not reduce existing flood risk
Washlands / water meadows	Designated areas of floodplain deliberately allowed to flood to temporarily store excess water	Free; natural; reduces flood peak; maintains biodiversity; no maintenance needed	Takes agricultural land out of production; only useful for moderate floods; landowner compensation needed

Exam Tip: For "evaluate" questions on river management, always consider: **effectiveness, cost, sustainability, impact on people and environment, and downstream effects**. Hard engineering tends to be effective short-term but can transfer the problem downstream. Soft engineering is more sustainable but may take time to work and requires large areas of land.

10. Example of a UK River Valley — The River Tees

Edexcel B asks you to study a named UK river landscape and to identify its major landforms of erosion and deposition. The **River Tees** rises at Cross Fell in the Pennines (about 893 m) and flows around 137 km east to the North Sea at Middlesbrough.

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Course	Landforms	Detail
Upper course	V-shaped valley, interlocking spurs, waterfalls and gorge	**High Force** (21 m) — the river falls over hard Whin Sill dolerite lying above softer limestone and shale. Undercutting and collapse have made the waterfall retreat upstream, leaving a gorge about 700 m long.
Middle course	Meanders, river cliffs, slip-off slopes	Near Barnard Castle and Yarm, the valley widens and the river meanders across a flat floor.
Lower course	Large meanders, ox-bow lakes, floodplain, levees, estuary	Large meanders near Stockton-on-Tees; ox-bow lakes form as necks are cut through; the Tees estuary at Teesmouth has mudflats and salt marsh, an important wildlife habitat.

11. Case Study — A UK Flood Management Scheme: Banbury, Oxfordshire

Case Study: Banbury Flood Alleviation Scheme (completed 2012)

Why was the scheme needed?

- Banbury lies on the floodplain of the **River Cherwell**. Major floods in 1998 and 2007 flooded homes, businesses and the main railway line.
- In 1998, around 150 homes and businesses were flooded, costing about £12.5 million, and the town's railway and main roads were closed.
- Over 440 homes and 70 businesses remained at risk, along with the railway station and the M40 access route.

The management strategy:

- A **flood storage reservoir** was created north of the town by building a 2.9 km clay **embankment** across the floodplain. During a flood it can hold back up to 3 million m^3 of water and release it slowly.
- A raised section of the A361 road was built so the road stays open during floods.
- Flood walls and earth banks protect the industrial estate and railway.

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- A new pumping station removes surface water; a biodiversity area with ponds, hedges and trees was created.

Social, economic and environmental issues:

Social	Economic	Environmental
Homes and businesses now protected; residents' stress and insurance worries reduced; railway and roads stay open	Cost about £18.5 million (Environment Agency, Cherwell District Council and local businesses); estimated to prevent over £100 million of flood damage over its lifetime; some farmland used for storage	New wildlife habitat (ponds, wetland, 4,000 m of new hedgerows); the embankment changed the appearance of the floodplain; during construction there was disruption to habitats

Evaluation: The scheme combined hard engineering (embankment, walls) with soft features (floodplain storage, habitat creation). It protects against a 1-in-200-year flood. It has held back water successfully in several high-flow events since 2012.

Exam Tip: Flood management questions usually ask *why* the scheme was needed, *what* was done, and its *social, economic and environmental issues*. Learn two or three facts for each — specific numbers (cost, homes protected, storage volume) lift your answer to the top level.

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